thorough independent analysis over time of caste representation among political-party candidates and representatives in UP.

BJP's Big Caste Shift: What the Mehta–Singh Social Index Topline Numbers Tell Us

The findings of the Mehta–Singh Social Index shed new light on the BJP's social engineering experiments with caste in UP. They offer a radically different picture from what most conventional scholarship has been telling us about the party's power structures. They force a major rethink of traditional assumptions about the BJP and shed new light on the reasons behind its recent electoral successes. The Mehta–Singh Social Index Project demonstrates that, in the decade between 2009 and 2019:

- The BJP systematically increased OBC representation in very significant numbers at every level of its political organisation in UP: from district-level presidents to state-unit leaders to the council of ministers to assembly and national election candidates.
- OBCs became by far the single most represented caste category in the BJP at every organisational level.
- OBC representation in the BJP is far higher than acknowledged by scholars so far. This difference is of large magnitude and not just an incremental one.
- Not only did the BJP systematically increase OBC representation, this expansion was primarily based on non-Yadav OBCs (over twenty sub-categories like Kurmis, Jats, Sainis, Mauryas, etc.). These castes did not have such representation in the previous OBC-dominated Akhilesh Yadav-led administration of the SP, which was dominated by Yadavs.
- Similarly, the BJP systematically increased SC representation, though to a lesser extent than OBCs. Again, it did so by focusing on non-Jatav SC sub-castes (over seventeen sub-categories such as Pasis, Dhobis, Valmikis, etc.) that did not have such representation in the previous SC-led administration under BSP's Mayawati where Jatavs were dominant.